BOOKS

Southern Sojourn

AMBORISH ROYCHOUDHURY'S *SRIDEVI: THE SOUTH YEARS* THROWS LIGHT ON THE ACTOR'S EARLY YEARS OF STARDOM BEFORE SHE MADE IT EVEN BIGGER IN BOLLYWOOD



When 13-year-old Sridevi did her first full-fledged role as a Tamil film heroine in *Moondru Mudichu* (1976), in terms of experience, she was already senior to co-actors Kamal Haasan and Rajinikanth. She had seven years of acting behind her, while Haasan had six (three as a child actor) and Rajinikanth had barely begun. Sridevi—at 13, I remind you—played the 18-year-old vengeful *stepmother* of the villain Rajinikanth.

Amborish Roychoudhury's *Sridevi* is filled with such delightful moments of discovery for the Hindi cinema viewer. Given the handicap of Sridevi's lifelong reticence, the book succeeds remarkably in fleshing out the early life of the actor. Filled with stories of her milestone Tamil, Telugu, Malayalam and Kannada films, and supported by interviews, the book is an account of the 'other' Sridevi whom Hindi film audiences didn't get to see. It postulates that this Sridevi was the real actor, chewing on meaty and varied—at times experimental—roles. In comparison, Hindi cinema made a diva of her, mostly playing up her oomph and charisma, says the writer.

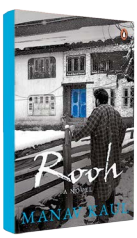
It is moving to think of little Sridevi as an "actor who grew up on sets" and knew no other life, going from child actor who debuted at six to a heroine at 13. Thanks to her success as cherubic god Muruga in her first film *Thunaivan* (1969), she was swamped with work and received no schooling. Perhaps because of this, she was utterly dependent on her mother, even as an adult; Haasan remembers her being fed by her mother. But as YouTube clips cited by Roychoudhury show, young Sridevi was born to do this work, owning the screen with innate self-confidence from her first appearance. And, as she said, "I thoroughly enjoyed the film atmosphere."

Roychoudhury does an excellent job of providing context to readers who may be familiar only with Sridevi's Bombay films, via discussions of her co-actors (especially Haasan and Rajinikanth) and directors. We get insights into the legends who dominated 20th-century southern cinema and politics: M.G. Ramachandran, Jayalalithaa, N.T. Rama Rao, K. Karunanidhi, as well as directors like K. Balachander, Bharathiraja, K. Bhagyaraj, K. Raghavendra Rao, I.V. Sasi—all of whom Sridevi worked with. That the thespians she grew up with were her 'school' is a major point made in the book. Her vast reper-

BOOKS

Soul of the Valley

While Manav Kaul's* Rooh *is a fictional account of a journey through Kashmir, it's really about the writer's inner journey



ROOH
by Manav Kaul
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THE PLAYS HE HAS SCRIPTED and directed, the film roles he has essayed, the many novels, short stories, and anthologies of poems that he has written in Hindi, all of them are quintessentially Manav Kaul. Each, intense and introspective, and drawing from the deeply personal. In that sense, his latest novel titled *Rooh*, ostensibly a travelogue through Kashmir, is also more about the journey within rather than a descriptive documentation of the Valley's beauty. Kaul travels through Srinagar, Gulmarg, Baramulla, even treks up to the stunning Tarsar Lake. But don't expect a touristy travel tale. This one is an exploration into his inner self, sometimes heartwarming, often heart-rending. The story works on several different levels. Sprinkled throughout are incidents that occurred in his early years in his home in Khawaja Bagh, Kashmir, as well as in Hoshangabad, Madhya Pradesh, where his family relocated when the situation in the valley became difficult for the Pandits. There's the deep impact of his first visit going back there as an adult, with the charismatic and enigmatic Rooh, a foreigner who seems to know more about Kashmir than its prodigal son. And there's the current journey that he is undertaking with another Roohani, revisiting all the places he holds dear, but which also fill him with fear. These universes intersect and overlay each other as you are taken on an internal voyage of discovery. You find yourself being drawn deep into his turbulent thoughts through every page of *Rooh*, even if at some points it does come across as a tad too indulgent. His stream-of-consciousness narrative is an expression of all the emotions surrounding his relationship with his father and how the memories of childhood and

Manav Kaul's *Rooh* is an exploration into his inner world, sometimes heartwarming, often heart-rending